SHARED RECOVERY, SUSTAINED CELL RESPONSES, AND TRAINING GAINS IN ARBITRARY-SCALE SUPER-RESOLUTION

Anonymous authors

Anonymous institution

ABSTRACT

Arbitrary-scale super-resolution exhibits shared frequency recovery, sustained responses to cell size, and gains from cell-conditioned learning. First, tested decoder families share recovery profiles, while stronger encoders, larger MLPs and longer training help mainly above input-normalised frequency $u \approx 0.75$: longer training changes recovery below this boundary by at most 0.0013. Low-frequency saturation persists under Gaussian blur. Second, at equal decoder-input steps, cell-induced output changes generally remain as large or grow with scale: $J_6/J_2 \geq 1$ in 11 of 12 conditions, with point estimates 0.94–2.47. This descriptive pattern separates sustained output response from declining fixed-multiplier cost, which combines shrinking input steps and error alignment. Third, removing cell during training loses about 0.10 dB in a matched two-seed benchmark. Constant-cell and shuffled-cell controls retain the input dimensions to test whether correct scale pairing explains this gain; these 200-epoch comparisons are in progress, so its source remains unresolved. Together, the findings distinguish where capacity helps, how cell changes the output, and what remains to be explained about its training benefit.

***Index Terms*—** Arbitrary-scale super-resolution, implicit representation, frequency recovery, scale conditioning

1. INTRODUCTION

Continuous-coordinate super-resolution decodes local image features at arbitrary output locations. LIIF [1] conditions this decoder on target pixel size, or *cell*; subsequent designs use local Fourier estimators [2], integrated positional encoding [3], implicit attention [4], neural operators [5], Gaussian splatting [6] or heat-field filtering [7]. Which parts of the recovered signal benefit from these choices, and what information does cell contribute?

Prior work links performance to model size and training [8] and studies spectral decoding's efficiency–accuracy trade-off [9]. HyRA analyses nonlinear compensation of low-pass phase distortion [10]; LIIF, integrated encoding and heat fields connect cell to edges and filtering [1, 3, 7]. We locate capacity gains and distinguish cell-induced output change, error cost and training benefit.

Our findings are: (1) decoder families share recovery profiles, with capacity gains mainly above $u \approx 0.75$ and lower-band changes no larger than 0.0013 from longer training; (2) equal-step cell response is sustained or larger at $\times 6$ than $\times 2$ in 11/12 conditions, separating response strength from error cost; and (3) cell improves learning by about 0.10 dB, with dimension-preserving controls testing the source of this gain. The third finding's source awaits the ongoing training controls; Table 2 retains all prediction failures.

2. SHARED RECOVERY PROFILES AND CAPACITY

Models and measurement. LIIF, LTE and SC-INR (an LTE-derived experimental variant with analytic sinc cell weights) use the EDSR-baseline architecture [11], separately learned encoder weights and a common DIV2K [12] recipe: scales from $\mathcal{U}(1, 4)$, 1000 epochs and three seeds. GaussianSR uses an external 2000-epoch EDSR checkpoint and provides an additional comparison. Matched 200-epoch LIIF arms change the encoder to RDN [13] or SwinIR [14], reduce the MLP from 4×256 to 2×64, or remove cell. These comparisons match recipes; parameter counts and compute differ.

Let $r = \max(|f_x|, |f_y|)$ be frequency in cycles per output pixel and $u = 2sr$ its value relative to the input Nyquist limit at scale s. Recovery in band b is $R_b = 1 - V_b/E_b$, where error energy V_b and target energy E_b are pooled over images before taking the ratio. Original crop analyses use DIV2K 0869–0900, 240^2 centre crops, quarter-u bins, anti-aliased bicubic inputs and a four-pixel shave. Full-image recovery additionally covers Set14 [15], BSD100 [16] and Urban100 [17]. We evaluate $\times 2/3/4/6$; $\times 6$ lies outside the training scale range.

A shared recovery regime. Across $\times 2/3/4$, the three matched decoder families have a maximum scale-specific band spread of 0.010, attained at $\times 4$, in the registered $0.5 \leq u < 2$ comparison (paired image-bootstrap 95% interval $[0.007, 0.016]$ at that scale). With GaussianSR included, all 54 full-image dataset–scale–band comparisons stay below 0.019. Closely shared profiles extend across the tested decoder forms and image collections (Fig. 1a,b), although the stricter cross-scale-collapse prediction fails its registered tolerance gates.

Capacity improves the incompletely recovered bands. Longer training, stronger encoders and a larger MLP change recovery primarily from $u \approx 0.75$ upward (Fig. 1c). From

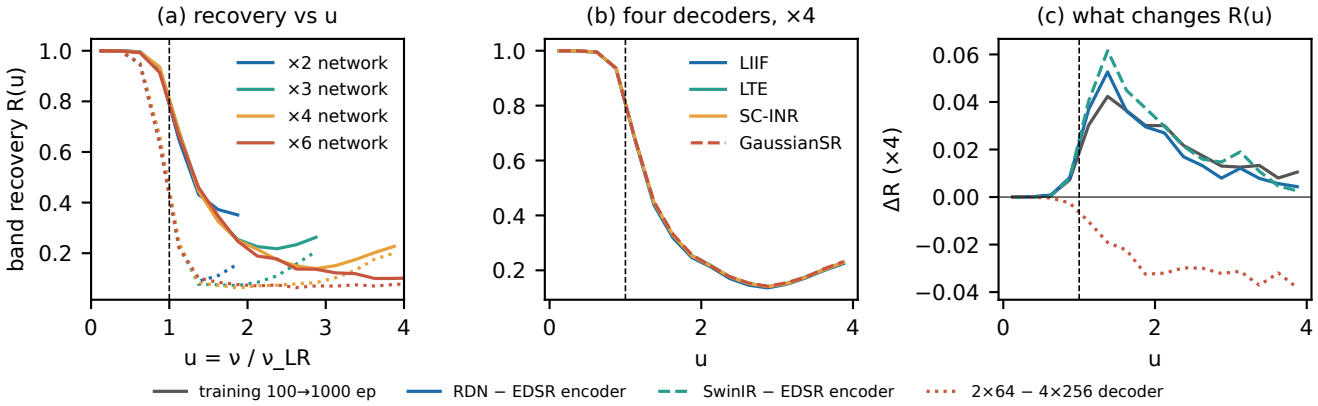


Fig. 1. Shared recovery profiles and frequency-localised capacity effects. (a) Three decoder families and three seeds at four scales; dotted curves are bicubic. (b) Decoder comparison at $\times 4$; GaussianSR is an external checkpoint with a different recipe. (c) Effects of training duration, encoder and MLP capacity. The plotted points represent frequency bands.

epoch 100 to 1000, gains in $1 \le u < 2$ range from 0.0245 to 0.0464 across the three decoder families and $\times 2/3/4$, while changes below $u = 0.75$ are at most 0.0013. Matched RDN and smaller-MLP experiments replicate the high-frequency improvement and loss, respectively, with a second training seed. Decoder form and decoder capacity therefore have distinct empirical effects.

After retraining with Gaussian blur ($\sigma = 0.6s$ HR pixels) and non-antialiased bicubic resizing, RDN improves PSNR at all scales but changes recovery below $u = 0.75$ by at most 0.0006, failing the registered lower-band-gain prediction. This one-seed result extends low-frequency saturation to a second degradation. Table 1 and Fig. 3 show benchmark and visual effects.

3. CELL RESPONSES PERSIST AS SCALE INCREASES

Equal multipliers imply unequal interventions. For output side length L, the implementations multiply the supplied cell $2/L$ by the LR feature-grid size L/s. The decoder receives $c = 2/s$ on each axis. Multiplying cell by m therefore gives the per-axis step

$$h = \frac{2(m-1)}{s}, \qquad m = 1 + \frac{hs}{2}. \tag{1}$$

For fixed $m = 2$, this step falls from 1 to $1/3$ between $\times 2$ and $\times 6$. A declining perturbation cost consequently combines changing input step with changing network response.

For native prediction P, perturbed prediction P_h, target T, native error $e = T - P$ and output change $\delta = P_h - P$, the MSE change is

$$D = \|e - \delta\|^2 - \|e\|^2 = \underbrace{\|\delta\|^2}_{J} - 2\,\mathrm{Re}\langle e, \delta\rangle. \tag{2}$$

We report J, D and the alignment term in RGB-mean MSE units. Small cost can arise from an output change that corrects existing error. The dB cost additionally depends on native MSE V through $10\log_{10}(1 + D/V)$.

Sustained equal-step response. At the same decoder-input step, cell-induced output changes generally do not weaken with scale and are often larger (Fig. 2). Across four datasets and three steps, $J_6/J_2 \ge 1$ in 11/12 conditions; point estimates span 0.94–2.47. The individual 95% interval lower bounds span 0.81–1.57 and upper bounds 1.08–4.48; these ranges summarise 12 intervals, not a pooled interval. The smallest estimate is Urban100 at $h = 0.25$, 0.94 $[0.81, 1.08]$, and the largest is Set14 at $h = -0.25$, 2.47 $[1.47, 4.48]$. This is a descriptive endpoint pattern, not a new preregistered success or a claim that every response increases significantly.

The frozen experiment measures all 246 full images from DIV2K 0869–0900, Set14, BSD100 and Urban100 with LIIF/LTE/SC-INR, two seeds and $h \in \{-0.25, 0.25, 0.5\}$, using paired within-dataset image bootstrap intervals. Matched image support, preprocessing, 10,000 resamples and multiplicity rules are documented in the repository; Table 2 separately reports the frozen existence, condition-wise and Set14 endpoint tests, including the failed Set14 prediction.

Response and cost can move in opposite directions. On BSD100 at $h = 0.5$, $J_6/J_2 = 1.24$ $[1.06, 1.44]$, but D falls from 79.42 to 40.77 in 10^{-6} MSE (paired change -38.65 $[-55.13, -22.01]$; descriptive 95% intervals, without multiplicity correction). Across datasets at this step, $r \ge 0.375$ accounts for 43.5–50.7% of J at $\times 2$, but only 2.4–3.0% at $\times 6$; the middle band $r \in [0.1875, 0.375)$ accounts for 60.5–66.7% at $\times 6$.

These finite interventions compare responses across changing features and native conditions. Negative steps leave the training cell interval at some scales, and native $\times 6$ is outside

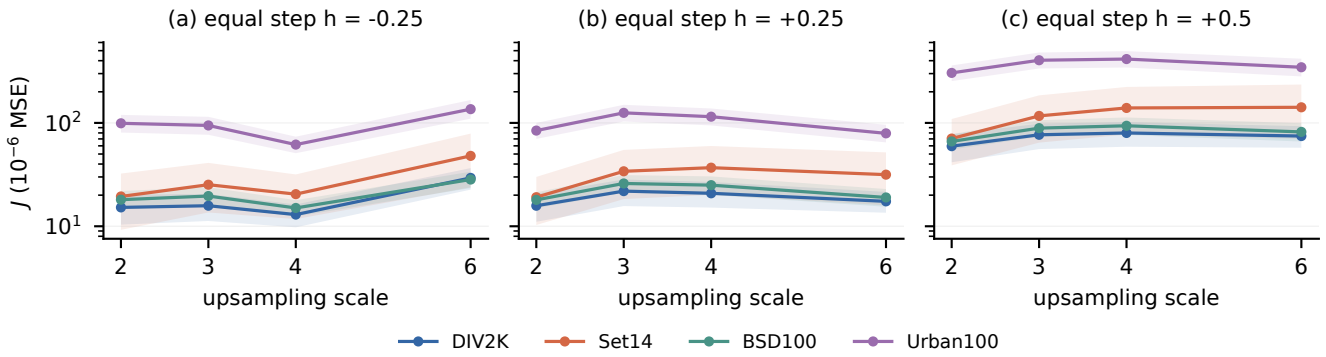


Fig. 2. Equal-step output responses need not decrease with scale. Each curve averages three decoder families and two seeds on one full-image dataset. Shading shows pointwise 95% paired-image bootstrap intervals, conditional on these checkpoints; the logarithmic axis reports J. Endpoint ratios are descriptive; the frozen prediction gates are reported separately in Table 2.

Table 1. Mean full-image Y-PSNR change (dB) relative to native EDSR-LIIF: four datasets, $\times 2/3/4/6$, matched 200-epoch arms and two seeds. Shuffled cell uses native cell at evaluation. †One seed. Parameter counts and compute differ for capacity changes.

Change	$\times 2$	$\times 3$	$\times 4$	$\times 6$
MLP 2×64	-0.25	-0.26	-0.28	-0.24
no cell input	-0.13	-0.09	-0.11	-0.10
constant cell		pending		
shuffled cell		pending		
RDN encoder	$+0.35$	$+0.29$	$+0.28$	$+0.25$
SwinIR encoder†	$+0.46$	$+0.42$	$+0.42$	$+0.34$

it; marginal support is reported for each condition.

Scope of a scalar explanation. A retrospective real-gain fit gives $Q = \sum_b (1 - w_b)^2 R_b E_b$, fitting w_b to native and perturbed outputs. In the original DIV2K bands, doubled-cell Q/D is 0.44, 0.72, 0.81 and 2.50 at $\times 2/3/4/6$. Recovery and fitted-filter changes jointly account for 41.4% of the $\times 2 \to \times 6$ MSE-cost decline (Set14: 41.5%); alignment and non-scalar terms complete the accounting. Projections, image rankings and negative cases remain in the repository.

4. WHAT CELL CONTRIBUTES DURING LEARNING

Removing cell during training loses approximately 0.1 dB across benchmark scales in the existing two-seed comparison. To test the source of this benefit, we add two EDSR-LIIF arms under the same 200-epoch recipe and two seeds. Both retain the native decoder's two cell inputs and parameter count. Constant-input weights can be absorbed into the first-layer bias, adding no expressivity. The *constant* arm receives the training mean of the actual cell coordinate, $c_0 = \mathbb{E}[96/\,\mathrm{round}(48s)]$ for $s \sim \mathcal{U}(1, 4)$, at every query and evaluation geometry. The *shuffled* arm receives another sample's complete cell vector, using a random batch derangement. This preserves the empirical cell marginal while removing the correct pairing. A separate random generator preserves the data and model-initialisation streams, and assignment statistics verify the intervention. Queries and image features can still carry other scale cues.

We freeze predictions and scoring before training, select epoch 200 regardless of validation, and reevaluate the existing native/no-cell checkpoints with the same evaluator. Standard full-image Y-PSNR follows the original PIL-bicubic protocol, clamps outputs and shaves by scale on Set5, Set14, BSD100 and Urban100. We also measure quarter-u recovery on the original DIV2K crop cohort. The shuffled arm's primary evaluation uses native cell; fixed-mean and four independent marginal-cell assignments per image provide predeclared sensitivity checks.

The primary predictions require native cell to outperform each new arm by at least 0.05 dB in the dataset- and scale-balanced mean, with both seeds positive and a Bonferroni-adjusted 97.5% paired-image interval above zero. Separate equivalence tests ask whether each arm lies within ± 0.03 dB of no-cell; failure to establish equivalence is retained. Training comparisons use 2,000 within-dataset paired image resamples, conditional on the two seeds.

Training-control status. All four frozen 200-epoch runs are in progress. Benchmark effects, recovery localisation, inference-policy sensitivity and the four prediction verdicts will be reported after the integrated pipeline completes; no partial validation result is used as a final outcome. These contrasts assess correct pairing, retained dimensions and training noise; their interpretation is limited to this recipe.

5. CONCLUSION AND SCOPE

Recovery profiles are shared across tested decoders, while capacity gains concentrate above $u \approx 0.75$. At equal decoder-

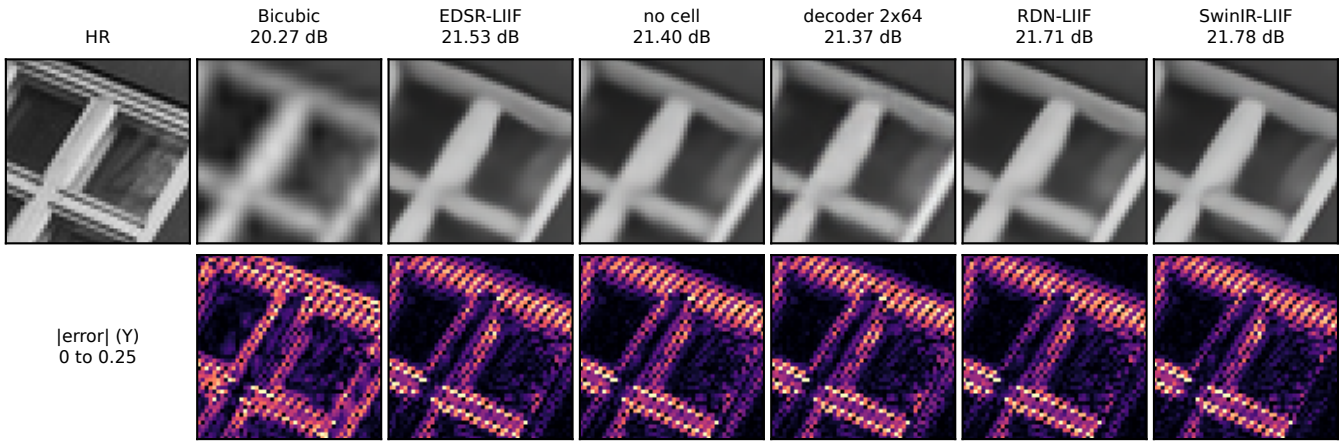


Fig. 3. Rule-selected $\times 4$ recovery example, Urban100 img_036. Before visual inspection, the image is selected at the upper-median rank of whole-image RDN–EDSR Y-PSNR gain (51st of 100); the 48×48 window maximises HR gradient energy on a stride-eight grid. Top: reconstructions and window Y-PSNR. Bottom: absolute Y error, shared range $[0, 0.25]$. The fixed example illustrates the existing capacity and no-cell arms.

input steps, cell response is sustained or larger in 11/12 endpoint comparisons. Shrinking steps and error alignment explain why a fixed-multiplier cost decline need not mean weaker output response. Cell improves learning by about 0.10 dB; the constant/shuffled-cell comparisons will distinguish the role of correct pairing from retained input dimensions. Their source verdict remains pending.

Evidence is limited to the tested architectures, recipes and two degradations. New measurements were specified prospectively on previously studied images/checkpoints. Image-bootstrap intervals condition on fixed trained seeds; finite interventions and ablations do not identify a unique internal mechanism.

Table 2. Registered predictions and retained failures. Counts are satisfying checks, followed by overall pass (P) or fail (F); they are not independent experiments. All original prediction records remain in the repository. Stages 17–18 are frozen prospectively. Stage 17 uses one-sided Bonferroni bounds over 36 adjacent tests, three tests per condition, or two Set14 endpoints; the 11/12 descriptive endpoint count is not a new prediction.

Prediction	Outcome
strict $R(u)$ collapse (crops; full)	45/54; 53/72 F
decoder spread ≤ 0.03 (crops; full)	36/36; 54/54 P
doubled-cell peak $r \in [.19, .375)$	36/36 P
fixed-multiplier cost declines	9/9 P
$Q/D \in [.7, 1.3]$ at $\times 3/4$	6/6 P
best cell within 10% of native ($s \leq 4$)	20/27 F
smaller cell costs more	33/144 F
small MLP harmless at large scales	F
blur moves gains below $u = 0.75$	0/3 F
$\geq 80\%$ absolute cost lies at $u \geq 1$	311/414 F
external RDN-BTC; EDSR gain	0/12; 0/4 F
external cell locus (GaussianSR; BTC)	2/4; 3/4 F
no-cell loss decays to negligible cost	F
17: $\geq 1/36$ corrected increases $> 10\%$	11/36 P
17: increase in all 12 conditions	12/12 P
17: both positive-step Set14 endpoints	1/2 F
18: native advantage (constant; shuffle)	pending
18: no-cell equivalence (constant; shuffle)	pending

6. REFERENCES

[1] Yinbo Chen, Sifei Liu, and Xiaolong Wang, "Learning continuous image representation with local implicit image function," in *CVPR*, 2021.

[2] Jaewon Lee and Kyong Hwan Jin, "Local texture estimator for implicit representation function," in *CVPR*, 2022.

[3] Ying-Tian Liu, Yuan-Chen Guo, and Song-Hai Zhang, "Enhancing multi-scale implicit learning in image super-resolution with integrated positional encoding," arXiv:2112.05756, 2021.

[4] Jiezhang Cao et al., "CiaoSR: Continuous implicit attention-in-attention network for arbitrary-scale image super-resolution," in *CVPR*, 2023.

[5] Min Wei and Xuesong Zhang, "Super-resolution neural operator," in *CVPR*, 2023.

[6] Jintong Hu, Bin Xia, Bin Chen, Wenming Yang, and Lei Zhang, "GaussianSR: High fidelity 2d gaussian splatting for arbitrary-scale image super-resolution," in *AAAI*, 2025.

[7] Alexander Becker, Rodrigo Caye Daudt, Dominik Narnhofer, Torben Peters, Nando Metzger, Jan Dirk Wegner, and Konrad Schindler, "Thera: Aliasing-free arbitrary-scale super-resolution with neural heat fields," *Transactions on Machine Learning Research*, 2025.

[8] Tayyab Nasir, Daochang Liu, and Ajmal Mian, "Implicit neural representation-based continuous single image super-resolution: An empirical benchmark," arXiv:2601.17723v3, 2026.

[9] Max Shad and Naeem Khoshnevis, "GB-LSR: Local spectral decoding with a learned global bandwidth for arbitrary-scale super-resolution," arXiv:2606.19617, 2026.

[10] Haoyu Deng, Zijing Xu, Yule Duan, Xiao Wu, Wenjie Shu, and Liang-Jian Deng, "Exploring the low-pass filtering behavior in image super-resolution," in *ICML*, 2024.

[11] Bee Lim, Sanghyun Son, Heewon Kim, Seungjun Nah, and Kyoung Mu Lee, "Enhanced deep residual networks for single image super-resolution," in *CVPR Workshops*, 2017.

[12] Eirikur Agustsson and Radu Timofte, "Ntire 2017 challenge on single image super-resolution: Dataset and study," in *Proceedings of the IEEE Conference on Computer Vision and Pattern Recognition Workshops*, 2017, pp. 126–135.

[13] Yulun Zhang, Yapeng Tian, Yu Kong, Bineng Zhong, and Yun Fu, "Residual dense network for image super-resolution," in *CVPR*, 2018.

[14] Jingyun Liang, Jiezhang Cao, Guolei Sun, Kai Zhang, Luc Van Gool, and Radu Timofte, "SwinIR: Image restoration using swin transformer," in *ICCV Workshops*, 2021.

[15] Roman Zeyde, Michael Elad, and Matan Protter, "On single image scale-up using sparse-representations," in *Curves and Surfaces*, pp. 711–730. Springer, 2012.

[16] David R. Martin, Charless Fowlkes, Doron Tal, and Jitendra Malik, "A database of human segmented natural images and its application to evaluating segmentation algorithms and measuring ecological statistics," Tech. Rep. UCB/CSD-01-1133, EECS Department, University of California, Berkeley, 2001.

[17] Jia-Bin Huang, Abhishek Singh, and Narendra Ahuja, "Single image super-resolution from transformed self-exemplars," in *Proceedings of the IEEE Conference on Computer Vision and Pattern Recognition*, 2015, pp. 5197–5206.